



THE FINANCIAL CLUB

NORTH AMERICA / EMEA / ASIA / LATAM

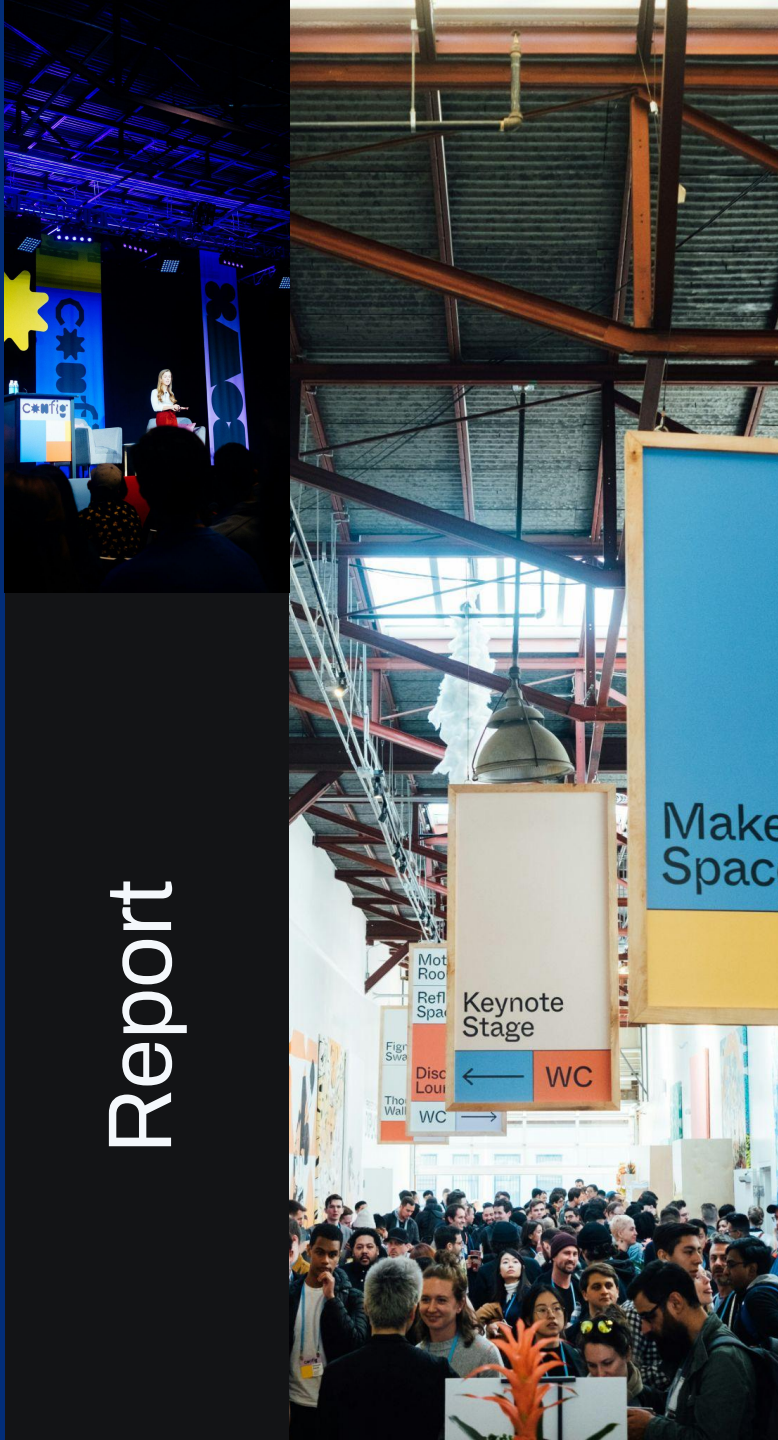
# Fintech Conference Industry Report 2026:

The Evolution of the Conference Business Model

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# Conference Business Model

## Report



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## Context

Over the past few years, the biggest force reshaping fintech conferences has been simple: ROI pressure.

Sponsors and attendees are optimizing less for content volume and more for business outcomes — meetings that drive partnerships, pipeline, and revenue. That pressure intensified in the post-pandemic economic reset, as budgets tightened and event spend started getting evaluated like any other growth channel: what did we get back, and can we prove it?

This report explains the shift, who wins and loses under the old model, how organizers are reacting, and how Conference Hubs are designed to strengthen organizers by making the surrounding ecosystem navigable and measurable.

***"Since the financial crisis, people began to crave real connection and depth. The conference and event formula is being rethought around community and identity and belonging." - Simon Taylor, Founder at Fintech Brainfood***

In the current environment, the winning events aren't necessarily the ones with the most stages — they're the ones that make it easiest to convert time in town into measurable progress: meetings completed, partnerships initiated, pipeline created, and follow-up actions taken.

This shift in incentives is what's driving the next iteration of the conference business model.

At the same time, conferences didn't lose relevance — they expanded. The flagship event still anchors legitimacy and travel, but side events, curated activations, and city-wide programming increasingly shape the outcomes participants attribute to the trip.



Supply Map:  
How Many Fintech/Adjacent Conferences Are Happening by  
Region (2026)

A scan of the 2026 fintech/adjacent events landscape shows a broad global footprint across North America, Europe, Middle East, Africa, Asia/Asia Pacific, LATAM, plus some Virtual/Global listings

Method note (important):  
We used the dataset from: FintechEvents.co - a curated list that includes fintech and adjacent tech/crypto/innovation conferences, so treat these counts as a directional “market activity index,” not an exhaustive census of all fintech events globally.



47

North America

47

EMEA

9

APAC

4

LATAM

107

Total



## The Structural Shift: Conferences Became Ecosystems

For a decade, the conference model followed a familiar formula: organizers concentrated decision-makers, sponsors gained structured access, and attendees showed up because the right people were in one place.

Over the past few years, that formula hasn't disappeared — it has expanded. Many conferences now function as destinations that drive value not only through the official program, but also through the broader set of gatherings happening around them: curated dinners, roundtables, partner activations, and satellite programming across the host city.

***“The future of conferences isn't about being the loudest room; it's about being the most connected one. We are moving from a world of passive attendance to one of engineered outcomes.” - Michelle Beyo, founder at Finavator***

The venue still provides legitimacy, scale, and a shared reason to travel. What's changed is that the highest-signal engagement is increasingly distributed across multiple formats — and organizers who embrace that reality can make their events more valuable for attendees, sponsors, and the host city.

This report isn't about conferences losing relevance. It's about conferences evolving into multi-format experiences — and the organizers who lean into that shift can make participation measurably more productive.



## Winners and Losers in the Old Model: When Engagement Extends Beyond the Venue

As side events and satellite programming became more important, the old model created clear winners — and it also created a growing “fragmentation tax” for everyone else.



Decision-makers  
with insider  
access

Brands that can  
host and curate

Fast-moving  
vertical  
communities

Cities and local  
ecosystems

## Winners:

People already embedded in the network get the most leverage: fewer random collisions, more deliberate meetings, and better visibility into where the highest-value rooms will be.

Companies with strong networks can create small, targeted rooms — dinners, breakfasts, and networking activations — that feel highly specific and outcome-driven. These companies control the full activation flow — from invitation and registration to attendee data capture and follow-up. When your network and reputation are strong, these formats can produce meaningful ROI because you can reach the right audience, drive high-intent registrations, and convert conversations into next steps quickly.

In areas like digital assets, identity, AI fraud, and payments infrastructure, smaller formats adapt quickly to new narratives and partnerships. Niche communities can mobilize their audiences toward the most relevant parts of programming — official or satellite — with higher conversion.

When activity spreads across town, the economic impact expands beyond the venue: hotels, restaurants, venues, and local partners benefit.



Attendees who only follow the official agenda

They may get strong content, but can miss where relationship-building is actually concentrated. Without clear visibility into what's happening beyond the venue, they're disadvantaged and ROI becomes uneven — especially for first-time participants.

Sponsors who rely on booths alone

Booths still matter, but standard sponsorship inventory by itself can feel less efficient than high-signal activations. The new play is combining presence on the floor with curated moments that drive meetings, differentiation, and measurable outcomes. A booth paired with a strong activation can also pull in decision-makers who may never spend time on the expo floor.

Fast-moving vertical communities

Not because conferences are less important — but because when a meaningful share of engagement happens outside the organizer's line of sight, it becomes harder to:

- help attendees navigate effectively,
- optimize the full experience,
- retain and prove sponsor ROI,
- and strengthen the event's long-term defensibility.

Core issue: side events are now a permanent part of the landscape. The issue is that the ecosystem lacks a shared coordination and visibility layer.

## The Pivot: How Organizers React

As side events and satellite programming became more important, the old model created clear winners — and it also created a growing “fragmentation tax” for everyone else.



1

### Leaning heavily into curated 1:1 meetings

In some formats, organizers subsidize travel or attendance for service buyers, paired with a commitment to take a defined number of meetings with sellers.

2

### Investing in the “grand experience”

This approach can elevate perception and loyalty, but the ROI tends to skew toward brand and experience rather than directly measurable business outcomes.

3

### Building a “week” model via controlled lists of sponsored events

In practice, pay-to-play side programming can introduce friction and often results in lighter, less organic programming density.

4

### Hosting year-long roadshows

Smaller regional activations throughout the year help sustain momentum and drive attention toward a flagship (or multiple regional conferences).



## The Real Gap: Has Been The Tools



The ecosystem exists, but it's been run across scattered tools:

- multiple registration platforms (conference software plus separate side-event tools)
- spreadsheets and Notion docs listing side programming
- WhatsApp/Telegram group chats coordinating who's going where
- Calendly links powering meetings
- LinkedIn posts and DMs ("Are you in town for X?")

This fragmentation creates avoidable friction:

- attendees can't see the full landscape and plan efficiently
- hosts collide on time slots
- organizers can't easily measure or improve what's happening around their event.

## Proposed Solution Framework: Conference Hubs

Conference Hubs (live in beta on The Financial Club platform) strengthen conference organizers by keeping the official conference at the center of the week's experience—while making the surrounding ecosystem easier to navigate.

Conference Hubs provide a planning and visibility layer that keeps the official conference front and center while making the surrounding ecosystem easier to navigate.



# Fintech Meetup 26

Live Now

Official Event Description

The event where thousands of fintech professionals, banks, startups, and solution providers come to meet, connect, and grow.

Date  
Feb 1 - Feb 3, 2026

Location  
Las Vegas, USA

Status  
Live Now

Register

Who's Coming

Agenda

Side Events

Buzz



**Thomas Jackson** about 1 month ago  
Senior Research Scientist at Financial Innovation Lab

Super excited for Fintech Meetup 26! Anyone else flying in from New York? Would love to connect beforehand 🚀

♡ 5   ↩ 5 Reply



**Amanda Garcia** about 1 month ago  
Financial Advisor at WealthTech Advisors

- They connect the official agenda and registration links with a unified view of the week (including satellite events and side programming)
- add an opt-in "I'm coming" signal so it's visible who's in town, and
- replace the current 5–6 tool patchwork with a shared coordination surface—helping organizers improve attendee and sponsor ROI,
- reach qualified in-town audiences who don't yet hold a ticket, and extend the value of the flagship event beyond the venue without losing coherence.

# Use Cases

## Use Case A: Fintech Meetup Pilot

Fintech Meetup is an example of a conference that leans into structured outcomes — recognizing that modern attendees optimize for meetings and partnerships as much as content.

Our pilot tests what happens when you add a coordination layer around the conference experience:

- clearer opt-in visibility into who's attending
- easier discovery of relevant satellite programming
- reach in-town guests without a ticket to the conference
- better planning workflows that convert “being there” into measurable meetings and follow-ups

For organizers, this is the unlock: improve attendee experience and sponsor ROI without having to “own” every side event — simply making the ecosystem legible.

## Use Case B: Fintech Week SF

Fintech Week SF is a first-edition example of coordinated city programming designed to help the ecosystem self-organize into a high-density week of curated gatherings.

The differentiation is coherence through one central hub:

- hosts can amplify events to a vetted audience
- events are discoverable in one place
- attendees can plan across multiple organizers without relying on group chats and hearsay
- the week becomes navigable rather than a scavenger hunt

Fintech Week SF is intentionally community-driven — a model for how distributed programming can be structured, productive, and attachable to any anchor conference.





## Industry Opinion

Dr. Lisa Cameron

President, The Financial Club



# Trust, Convening, and the Next Phase of the Conference Model

From my perspective as a policymaker, conference speaker, and host of private discussions and dinners, the conference model is not diminishing in importance — but the standard for what makes a conference valuable has clearly changed.

In fintech and financial services, trust is not a soft concept. It is a practical requirement. It affects who is willing to speak candidly, who is open to collaboration, and whether conversations move beyond introductions into meaningful action. It is also one of the main reasons I joined The Financial Club as President: the emphasis on trusted convening and high-quality dialogue reflects what I believe the industry increasingly needs.

What still works in the conference model is clear. Trusted conveners matter. People attend when the host's reputation signals credibility, quality, and seriousness of purpose. In a crowded market, that trust helps participants decide where to invest their time and attention.

Another strength in the current model is the rise of cross-sector rooms. Some of the most productive discussions now happen when policymakers, operators, institutions, investors, and technologists are brought together in the same conversation. These formats are particularly valuable in regulated and fast-moving sectors, where progress often depends on better understanding across stakeholder groups.

I would also highlight the importance of well-chaired discussions. Strong moderation has become a real differentiator. On complex topics, a skilled chair can improve the quality of a session significantly — not by speaking more, but by framing the issue properly, drawing out substance, and ensuring a balanced, useful exchange.

At the same time, there are clear areas where the model leaks value.

One is performative participation. Some sessions prioritize visibility over usefulness. They may look strong on paper, but they do not always produce the kind of dialogue that helps people make decisions, build partnerships, or advance practical work.



Dr. Lisa Cameron

President, The Financial Club

## Industry Opinion



Another is lack of continuity. Conferences can generate excellent conversations, but too often there is no structure to carry momentum forward. Without a mechanism for follow-up, introductions, or next-step coordination, much of the value created in the room is lost shortly after the event ends.

A third issue is misaligned participant mix. Even strong formats underperform when the room is not intentionally composed. Curation is not simply about exclusivity; it is about relevance and balance.

What is new — and increasingly important — is the growth of smaller, policy-facing and invitation-led formats around larger events. These settings often create the conditions for more candid and practical conversations. They are not a replacement for flagship conferences, but an important complement to them.

Participants also increasingly expect better pre-context: why they are in the room, what the discussion is trying to achieve, and who they will be engaging with. This improves participation quality and makes time more productive.

Looking ahead to 2026–2027, I believe the strongest conferences will be those that combine scale with trust. Large platforms and visible stages will remain important, but they will be most effective when paired with well-designed formats for smaller, higher-trust exchanges. Organizers will also be judged more by the quality of outcomes they enable — not simply attendance volume.

In my view, the future of conferences is not about choosing between visibility and curation. It is about designing environments where both can coexist. The events that lead will be the ones that understand that trust, preparation, moderation, and continuity are no longer optional enhancements — they are central to the value proposition./



Sanjib Kalita

Chairman, Fintech Meetup

## Industry Opinion



# Engaging the Ecosystem for Winning Fintech Events

Winning in the financial services industry is difficult, to say the least. Managing legal and regulatory requirements, while keeping up with technology advances, and developing products to fit market opportunities would seem foolhardy to most. 30 and 15 years ago, at the dawn of the internet and smartphone eras respectively, conventional wisdom was that new standalone products, services and entities would be best positioned to win market opportunities. The benefit of hindsight illustrates that long-term winners don't come from isolated ivory towers but from connected pragmatists.

We've seen a similar shift in financial services events as well. Older events, conceived 10-20 year ago, many of which I participated in or helped build, relied on fancy speakers to draw the largest of number of attendees into a single one-way conversation. With each passing year, there was a collective realization that the most productive time wasn't from sitting in a keynote presentation but from targeted one-on-one discussions. The greatest value wasn't from sitting passively in the venue but being an active participant in an ecosystem.

That has guided how we've developed Fintech Meetup and have decided to partner with organizations like The Financial Club. Both organizations believe that the industry is best served when ecosystem participation is easy, with peer-to-peer gatherings, focused on practical knowledge rather than mic-drop moments. I have personally experienced the friendly, approachable events that the Financial Club has organized around the country and am excited that Fintech Meetup will be the first event that starts to take advantage of the Financial Club's new platform.

Winning in financial services happens when companies create products that address customers needs better, faster and cheaper, while supporting regulatory requirements in a safe and responsible manner. Time and time again, I've seen that the winners aren't the ones that want to eat you for lunch, but the ones that want to take you to lunch. An ecosystem approach is best for the financial services industry and well as for industry events.



## Industry Opinion

Sanjib Kalita

Chairman, Fintech Meetup



At ecosystem-centric events, professionals at banks and credit unions can be exposed to new ideas, technologies and people that can dramatically improve user experiences. At ecosystem-centric events, innovators and entrepreneurs can have frank, open discussions about pain points that desperately need addressing. At ecosystem-centric events, regulators and system organizers can guide and assess products in the early, most-malleable state. If any of these participants are not actively participating at an event, results will not lead to long-term wins for the industry.

At Fintech Meetup, we've experienced great success with our meetings program for all of these sectors. Each attendee answers a brief set of questions about who they are, what they're interested in, and whom they might want to meet at the event. Our technology-driven platform simplifies discovery, scheduling, logistics, and follow up for meeting people at conference. This is expertly managed at large scale with amazing results – a 96% meeting attendance rate, a 93% satisfaction rate, and over 40,000 meetings completed over 2 days.

Just as the events we organize talk about using better technology, event organizers will also need to practice what their speakers preach. Technology platforms, like the one created by The Financial Club, will help engage communities to learn about, participate in, and get the most out of events. I look forward to new technologies that we haven't even envisioned that will help organizers go broader and deeper with ecosystems. As an award-winning event organizer for 2 decades, I look forward to the unknown journey ahead and how creative problem solving will help the industry reach new heights.



Michelle Beyo

Founder, Finavator

## Industry Opinion



# Unlocking the Connected Ecosystem: Why the Global Conference Model is Being Re-Engineered

As the industry evolves, it is vital for leaders to be aware of these shifting trends and ensure their strategies align to enable the maximum value for their ecosystem.

I have had the pleasure of attending and speaking at global events from Vegas to Amsterdam, London, Spain, New York, Barbados, and Toronto. Throughout that time, I have had a front-row seat to how the conference model has evolved. For a decade, the formula was simple: organizers gathered decision-makers under one roof, and attendees showed up because the key industry players were in the building.

Today, that's no longer enough. We are witnessing a massive shift driven by the need for proven results. Post-pandemic, with tighter budgets and more expensive capital, every dollar spent on an event is scrutinized. Sponsors and attendees want high signal meetings that turn into real partnerships and revenue.

“The future of conferences isn't about being the loudest room; it's about being the most connected one. We are moving from a world of passive attendance to one of engineered outcomes.”

### How I See the Landscape: Grounding the Experience

What works right now is moving away from the one size fits all approach and toward intentionality. I have many clients who host private dinners and focused side events that tackle hot trends like agentic payments and open finance before a big event even begins.

These curated sessions ground the broader experience. They turn a massive, overwhelming venue into high trust environments where time spent in town translates into tangible progress before the main stage doors even open.

However, the traditional model is losing value. As the report highlights, the highest signal engagements are increasingly distributed across curated dinners and satellite programming. While the main event acts as the anchor, the most important relationships are now being built at these off-site meetings across the city.



Michelle Beyo

Founder, Finavator

## Industry Opinion



If you only follow the official agenda, you miss the real connection points. For organizers, when the best engagement happens out of their sight, it becomes almost impossible to prove to a sponsor that their investment was worth it. We need to bridge this gap.

### What's Fading and What's Next: From Context to Connection

The era is changing as attendees are no longer able to travel across the world for content they can watch on a webinar as they need to justify the spend with the core value with number of meetings and connections.

The real gap in this evolution has been the tooling. Right now, this entire side event ecosystem is a mess and many don't have time to sort out the multiple events from different platforms. This is why The Financial Club's Conference Hubs can help bridge the gap between the official schedule and all those vital satellite events. This can help to remove the friction of trying to find where the real connections are happening, which helps to make the trip truly measurably more productive.

### My Predictions for 2026–2027

- \* The Operating System Event: In the next two years, the best conferences will stop acting like simple planners and start acting like infrastructure. They will provide the digital tools that allow everyone to organize and track their own sub events easily within the main conference's orbit.
- \* Verified Professional Identity: Just like the seamless data flows we advocate for in open banking, we will see the rise of verified professional IDs. As the report predicts, this will allow for smarter matching, ensuring you know exactly who you should meet and that they are vetted before you even board your flight.
- \* Results Based Sponsorship: I believe the old logo on a lanyard package will disappear. They will be replaced by performance-based tiers where sponsors pay based on the number of actual introductions and meetings the event facilitates.

I am excited for the beta launch of these tools from The Financial Club, as they will finally allow our ecosystem to optimize together and turn every event into a true engine for growth.



EDITION 3

**FINTECH HOUSE SF**

MARCH 11, 2026  
SAN FRANCISCO

HOSTED WITH **svb** Silicon Valley Bank

**Fintech House SF (3rd edition)**

Mar 11, 2026, 6:00 PM - 9:00 PM PDT

LOCATION  
532 Market St, San Francisco, CA 94104, ...

45 attendees

3 hosts

View Details

Edit

OFFICIAL DELEGATION TO

**FINTECH MEETUP 2026**

MARCH 30 - APRIL 1, 2026  
LAS VEGAS

**FINTECHMeetup**  
A Hyve Event

**Official Delegation to Fintech Meetup**

Mar 29, 2026, 10:00 AM - Apr 1, 2026, 12:00 PM

LOCATION  
3950 S Las Vegas Blvd, Las Vegas, NV 89119, ...

3 attendees

1 host

View Details

MAY 2026

EDITION 4

**CYBER CONNECT US**

MAY 11-12, 2026  
WASHINGTON, DC

**Cyber Connect**

May 11, 2026, 6:00 PM - May 12, 2026, 6:00 PM  
(Your time: May 11, 2026, 3:00 PM - May 12, 2026, 3:00 PM)

EDITION 4

**FINTECH HOUSE SF**

MAY 26, 2026  
SAN FRANCISCO

HOSTED WITH **svb** Silicon Valley Bank

**Fintech House SF (4th edition)**

May 26, 2026, 6:00 PM - 9:00 PM PDT

**FINTECH FEST 2.0**

MAY 28, 2026  
SAN FRANCISCO

**Fintech Fest 2.0**

May 28, 2026, 10:00 AM - 6:00 PM PDT

## Conference Hubs

High-trust networking around major fintech conferences — bringing together side events, schedules, and shared participation signals.

FWSF

**FINTECH WEEK SF**

2026  
MAY 26-29

ORGANIZED BY THE FINANCIAL CLUB

**Fintech Week SF**

Fintech Week SF is a city-wide week of fintech events across San Francisco, May 26-29, 2026. Organized by The Financial Club together with leading industry...

Date  
May 27 - May 30

Location  
San Francisco, US

View Details

FM

**FINTECHMeetup**

A Hyve Event

**Fintech Meetup 2026**

Fintech Meetup is the fintech industry's most productive and anticipated event of the year, where senior leaders from thousands of banks, credit unions, fintechs,...

Date  
Mar 29 - Apr 1

Location  
Las Vegas, USA

View Details

Explore the Fintech Meetup Conference Hub:  
<https://www.app.financialclub.com/conference-hub>

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